

Fuck Dating Apps.

The field note: what to do instead.

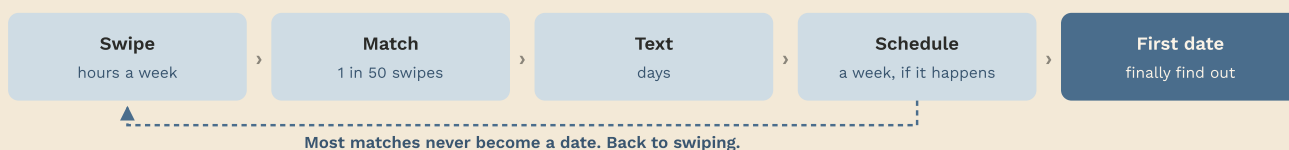
You've read why the apps keep you swiping. This is the other half: what to do with the hours you get back when you drop the apps.

APPS VS. IN PERSON

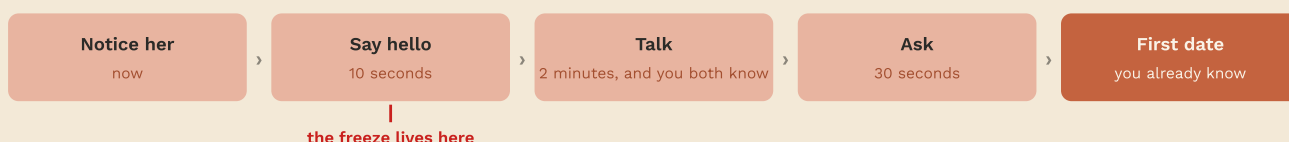
Two roads to the same first date.

The apps don't handle the first stages of dating. They trap you in them. Swipe, match, text, schedule, wait, and only on the date do you find out whether you feel good around her. In person, that answer arrives in the first two minutes, and every step trains a skill you keep.

On the apps weeks, and what it trains is writing a profile



In person minutes, and every step trains a skill you keep



The time labels are typical, not measured. The freeze at "say hello" is where everyone starts, and it's where the exercises below start too.

Before you say a word

Creepiness has a formula: hidden agenda plus ignored signals. Wanting to talk to her isn't creepy. Pretending you don't is where it gets weird. So be honest about why you're there, and read the room before you open your mouth.

Is she open to connection? How does she respond to your approach?

What you see	What it means	What you do
Headphones in, turned away, buried in her phone	Busy. Not a no to you, a no to everyone.	Leave her be.
Mid-conversation, in a hurry, at work	Not now. If she's working, she can't walk away from you.	Chat if it's natural. Don't pursue.
Short answers, no eye contact after your hello	She's said no.	"No worries, enjoy your day." Mean it. Go.
Eyes up, open to the room, lingering, looks back twice	Green light.	Say hello.
You honestly can't tell	Unclear is not a no.	One short hello. Her response is the answer.

The first sixty seconds

- **Say hello, with the truth.** "Hi, I noticed you and wanted to say hi. I'm [your name]." That's the whole opener. The honesty is what makes it land.
- **Ask one real question.** About right now: the book, the dog, the thing she's carrying, what she's up to today. Curiosity, not a line.
- **Listen.** Reply to what she actually said, not to what you planned to say next.
 - Notice your level of attraction: how excited are you to continue the conversation with her?
 - Notice her body language: does she turn toward you, hold eye contact, ask you something back?

- **Say what you want.** If it's going well: "I'd like to continue this conversation another time. Can I get your number?" Simple, direct, and easy to turn down.
- If she turns you down:
 - **Accept the "no" gracefully.** "No worries, have a nice day." Then actually leave. Lingering reads as creepy.
- If she seems excited:
 - **Make a clean exit.** "Great, I'll text you." Then go. A clear next step followed by a quick exit beats lingering.

The ladder: one step at a time

If you don't feel comfortable jumping straight to the full approach outlined above, start small. Stay on a rung until your body is bored there, then climb. Bored means trained.

- **Rung 1.** Ten seconds with a stranger, no goal. Ask for a recommendation, comment on the queue, hold the door and be polite.
- **Rung 2.** A genuine compliment to a stranger, about something she chose. The jacket, the book, the bike. Not her body. Leave without asking for anything.
- **Rung 3.** One real conversation with a woman you're *not* attracted to. A colleague, a neighbor, the person who makes your coffee.
- **Rung 4.** Run the full sixty second approach outlined above.

The freeze, and what to do with it

The freeze before you say hi is not a character flaw. It means you care - you're not a creep.

But it's also your untrained nervous system getting in the way of connection. Dating apps don't prepare you for in-person connection. The freeze lives in your body, not your head, so that's where you work with it.

Before an approach: feet on the floor. Three slow breaths, exhale longer than the inhale. Remind your body that it's safe right now. Then go, before your head catches up.

After a no: nothing to fix. Log it below. A no is information - not a personal judgement about you.

After a yes: Nice. Log it. Notice what your body did.

Approach log

Print this or copy it into your notes. Five reps a week is plenty. After your first five, email me and tell me what changed.

Day	Rung	What I said	What happened	Body Comfort (1 to 5)

Ready to actually meet someone?

Authentic Approach is a 3-month 1:1 container: nervous-system tools to settle the freeze, weekly real-world exercises, and a coach in your corner for the scary moments. Start with a free discovery call. Let's bring back in-person dating.

The program

marcuslevine.com/authentic-approach

Free discovery call

cal.com/marcuslevine/discovery

The research behind this note, with sources: marcuslevine.com/fuck-dating-apps.